LE JARDIN

# Facilitator guide

Workshop mode, the six acts, the eleven challenges and session plans

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https://permaculture-garden.vercel.app/?workshop=1&lang=en

# The game, workshop mode and the six acts

This guide is for anyone who plays Le Jardin with a group: a teacher, a youth worker, a community gardener. It covers how the game teaches, how to prepare the devices, what each of the six acts is for, the solutions to all eleven challenges, questions for the closing conversation and plans for 45, 90 and 120 minutes.

Le Jardin is a free browser game about designing a living permaculture garden, inspired by a real community garden in Menet, France. It needs no account and keeps the garden in the browser of the device it is played on. It is an independent project and is not affiliated with or endorsed by Erasmus+.

## How the game teaches

The player builds a garden out of **relationships**, not a collection of objects. Elements placed close together can form a *design connection* (rain harvesting beside a herb spiral, for example), wild neighbours arrive when the garden offers what they need, and four living layers (soil, water, food, habitat) grow stronger as they start to answer one another.

The guided journey leads through **six acts**. The first four describe the garden as it is now: an act is done while the garden really has that layer, and taking the element away undoes it. The fifth asks for a gift, the sixth for a turn of the season and one garden challenge.

Some rules hold everywhere in the game, and they are worth saying out loud to a group:

- **No timers and no penalties.** A wrong answer in a challenge gives a clue and another try. A challenge can also be left for later; it comes back.
- **Gifts never turn into personal money.** *Shares* are participation tokens, earned by noticing connections and by taking part. A gift to the community table strengthens the shared fund and goodwill, and it never buys anything back.
- **The AI never decides.** The optional *Living Lesson* names relationships in the garden and asks one question. Rules, points and outcomes always come from the game itself. In workshop mode the Living Lesson uses only the game's reviewed offline lessons.
- **The game simplifies.** Its facts carry the uncertainty they have in real gardens ("may", "can support"). For real planting, local conditions decide.

## Workshop mode

Give the group a link with `?workshop=1`. It works in every language of the game:

- English: https://permaculture-garden.vercel.app/?workshop=1&lang=en
- Czech: https://permaculture-garden.vercel.app/?workshop=1&lang=cs
- French: https://permaculture-garden.vercel.app/?workshop=1&lang=fr

English Čeština Français

What changes with the workshop link:

- **A garden of its own.** The workshop garden is saved apart from anyone's own game on the device. Players' own gardens are never read, changed or cleared.
- **A choice of where to begin.** The opening card asks *Where does this group begin?*: with the opening story (about one minute) or at any of the six acts. A later act starts with the earlier acts already done, using the plainest elements, placed far apart so that every design connection is still left for the group to find. Add `&act=3` to the link to preselect the third act on every device.
- **The same lesson for every group.** The Living Lesson answers only from the game's offline lessons: no AI, no cost, no network request.
- **A panel for the facilitator.** The *Workshop* button in the header (in the ▪▪▪ menu on a phone) replaces *Reset*. It opens *For the facilitator*: where this group is, a question to ask, the six acts with their goals, the session log, this guide, and *Prepare for the next group*.
- **A session log.** The device notes what the group does: when it began, each act completed, challenges solved (and how many other ways the group tried first), seasons, design connections, wild neighbours, gifts, Living Lesson experiments and certificates. It records no names and nothing a player writes. *Save as a file* gives a plain text file; *Print* prints the log on its own. Nothing in the log is sent anywhere.

## Before the session

- **Devices.** One device for two or three players works best; one per player is fine too. A laptop or tablet gives the most room; phones work in portrait and landscape. Charge everything.
- **Connection.** Open the workshop link on every device before the group arrives. Where the signal is weak, choose *Play without a connection* on each device beforehand (the arrow in the header; on a phone, in the ▪▪▪ menu): the download is about 20–35 MB, depending on whether you keep the Garden's voice and the music, and afterwards the game, the workshop link included, opens and plays without a connection. Other languages and the moving pictures still need one.
- **Language.** Choose it on the opening card or in the header. The garden speaks in English and Czech; in the other languages, including French, players read the text and hear the English voice.
- **Sound.** In a shared room, use headphones or switch the sound off with the speaker button in the header.
- **Start point.** Decide where the groups begin. Starting at a later act saves time and leads straight to the topic you want to discuss (see the plans below).
- **A pause.** The game saves itself after every step. A group can close the tab and continue later on the same device with the same link.
- **Between groups.** *Workshop* → save or print the log if you want it → *Prepare for the next group* → confirm. The device returns to the opening card, ready to start where the last group did.

## The six acts

### First act · Living soil

**Goal.** Living soil comes first: organic matter and cover feed the life that feeds every plant.

**In the game.** *Begin with my soil*: choose compost or mulch and place it where the bare ground needs care. The act is done while the garden has compost, mulch or a hügelkultur bed.

**Ask the group.** What lives in the soil, and what does it need from us before anything else can grow? What happens to bare soil on a hot, dry day?

**Common misconceptions.** Soil is only a place to hold plants. More digging is always better. The game rewards cover and a light touch.

**Tip.** At first the guided journey offers only compost and mulch. Before the group opens every tool, ask why the garden might want to start there.

## Second act · Every drop

**Goal.** Rain is caught, slowed and stored, so it serves the garden instead of rushing away.

**In the game.** *Catch and keep water*: add rain harvesting, then place a growing area nearby so the stored water has somewhere useful to go. The act is done while the garden has rain harvesting.

**Ask the group.** Where does the rain on this garden go now, and where could it pause and be useful? Why does the barrel have a lid?

**Common misconceptions.** Water from a roof is drinking water: it is not, and the game says so. A barrel alone solves the water question: the overflow needs a safe place to soak in.

**Tip.** When an element is selected, the plot marks circles where it would form a relationship. Placing it inside one makes the relationship visible.

## Third act · Useful abundance

**Goal.** Food grows in layers and partnerships, not as single crops standing alone.

**In the game.** *Grow food in layers*: add an edible bed, a fruit tree, a herb spiral or a planted arch. A seed bank can prepare crops, but the act is done when food is growing.

**Ask the group.** Which of your plants does more than one job, and what could you place beside it?

**Common misconceptions.** One useful pair of plants is a full plant guild: the game keeps the two apart, a pair is only a beginning. A garden with more objects is a better garden.

**Tip.** Compare two groups' gardens: who found a design connection, and how?

## Fourth act · Room for others

**Goal.** A resilient garden leaves room for wild neighbours, which need shelter and water as well as food.

**In the game.** *Make a home for wildlife*: plant a flower strip or add a bug hotel or a bird house.

**Ask the group.** Who else lives in this garden, and what does each of them need besides food?

**Common misconceptions.** Wild animals are pests, or rewards, or workers. A bug hotel guarantees residents: the game says "may", because nothing is guaranteed.

**Tip.** *Who might visit your garden* shows what each wild neighbour needs. Ask the group to read one out.

## Fifth act · Fair share

**Goal.** Fair share: a genuine surplus circulates as a gift and never turns into personal currency.

**In the game.** *Let one gift circulate*: pick a glowing cherry cluster and share it from the harvest basket at the community table. Later a genuine spare can go too: a second, established copy of an element, or finished compost, mulch or herb cuttings from one that has been through a season. The community table opens at this act.

**Ask the group.** What can the garden give away without becoming poorer, and why is a gift not a purchase here?

**Common misconceptions.** Shares are money. A gift should earn points. Sharing means giving away what the garden itself needs.

**Tip.** Point out the shared fund: it carries the whole garden through a bad year, and nobody owns it.

### Sixth act · Learn through change

**Goal.** Seasons change the garden; observe the whole system before acting on one symptom.

**In the game.** *Turn to the next season*: press *Next season* above the plot. A challenge meets the group there; solving it completes the act and leaves a lasting effect in the garden.

**Ask the group.** What changed with the season, and which other parts of the garden does that change reach?

**Common misconceptions.** A wrong answer is a failure: it is a clue. One quick fix solves a problem everywhere: the challenges ask what solves today's problem without creating tomorrow's.

**Tip.** The solutions to every challenge are on the next pages. Let the group try first; use the solution only to unblock.

### After the six acts

*Reflect on my garden* shows what the group has made and what remains. The seasons go on: a garden that has been through a full year, keeps every living layer at 45% or more, keeps two design connections active, has shared two gifts, harvested something and learned from three different challenges reaches the flourishing ending. There the group can write a name and save its **certificate of learning** as an image or print it. In a short session few groups get that far, and they do not need to: the six acts are the learning journey.

# The eleven challenges

A challenge meets the group each time the season turns. The game picks one that fits the garden as it is, preferring the ones played least. The task and the explanation below are the game's own words; the solution is there to unblock a group, not to read out at the start.

### 1. Soil moisture rescue

*Observe & conserve* · **When it appears:** Mulch is in the garden; any season except winter.

**The task.** Read the moisture tags and protect the four thirsty beds first. Beds above 50% can wait until the next barrow arrives.

**Solution.** Cover the four beds below 50%: **24%**, **31%**, **38%** and **45%**. The beds at 68% and 72% can wait for the next barrow.

**Why.** Mulch shades soil, slows evaporation and feeds soil life. Most cultivated beds benefit from suitable cover; when materials are scarce, observe first and protect the driest, most exposed soil.

**Ask the group.** Why did the driest beds come first, and what would have happened to them on a hot afternoon?

### 2. Feed the compost

*Turn waste into fertility* · **When it appears:** Compost is in the garden.

**The task.** Choose exactly four ingredients: two greens and two browns. Leave contaminants out, then build this new pile.

**Solution.** Exactly four: two greens from *Banana peel*, *Coffee grounds* and *Grass clippings*, and two browns from *Dry leaves*, *Plain cardboard* and *Small branches*. Leave out *Plastic bag* and *Cooked meat*.

**Why.** A new pile can begin with a varied mix of greens and browns, then be adjusted by observation. An existing cold, soggy pile usually needs dry browns, aeration and protection from excess rain — not more wet greens. Local compost rules may differ.

**Ask the group.** What do greens bring to the pile, what do browns bring, and why does air matter?

### 3. Test a layered wood bed

*Observe experimental systems* · **When it appears:** A hügelkultur bed is in the garden.

**The task.** Build one common layer sequence from the ground up, then plan to monitor settling, moisture and plant growth rather than assuming success.

**Solution.** From the ground up: *Logs & trunks* → *Branches & twigs* → *Leaves & straw* → *Finished compost* → *Topsoil & plants*.

**Why.** Logs, branches, organic matter, compost and soil are one common sequence — not a proven universal recipe. Avoid treated, diseased or invasive wood, expect settling and observe whether the bed actually helps in your conditions.

**Ask the group.** What would you watch in a real woody bed during its first dry summer?

### 4. Guide every drop

*Slow, spread & sink* · **When it appears:** Rain harvesting is in the garden; spring or summer.

**The task.** Complete the water journey in the right order, from the roof edge to soil that can absorb the overflow.

**Solution.** From the roof edge: *Gutter* → *Leaf screen* → *Covered barrel* → *Planted swale*.

**Why.** Guide suitable roof water through a gutter and screen into a stable, securely covered barrel, then send overflow to a safe infiltration area. Treat stored roof water as non-potable, follow local rules and use mosquito screening; roof materials affect where the water is safe to use.

**Ask the group.** Where does the overflow go, and why is stored roof water not for drinking?

## 5. Plan the winter pantry

*Store surplus wisely* · **When it appears:** The garden kitchen is built.

**The task.** Choose the best use or preservation method for each crate. A wrong choice reveals a clue, so you can rethink it.

**Solution.**

- *Jam*: Cherries make a bright preserve when cooked as jam.
- *Dry*: Apple slices dry well and keep with very little energy.
- *Ferment*: Salt and time turn cabbage into a stable ferment.
- *Dry*: Gentle air-drying keeps their fragrance.
- *Share fresh*: Tender leaves lose quality quickly, so share them fresh.
- *Cellar*: Cool, dark storage keeps roots firm for months.

**Why.** Jam fruit, dry apples and herbs, ferment cabbage, cellar roots and share tender leaves while they are fresh. Diversity in the pantry reduces waste.

**Ask the group.** Which harvest would you share today, and which would you keep for winter?

## 6. Restore the balance

*Work with living systems* · **When it appears:** Ladybugs live in the garden (flowers or a herb spiral, and a bug hotel); any season except winter.

**The task.** Select the three actions that support ladybugs, hoverflies and other natural predators, then restore balance.

**Solution.** Choose *Plant nectar flowers*, *Keep hollow stems* and *Observe for a few days*. Not *Use broad pesticide*, *Clear every wild corner* or *Leave soil bare*.

**Why.** Flowering plants feed adult predators, hollow stems offer shelter and patient observation gives them time to respond. Broad pesticides break this balance.

**Ask the group.** Why not simply spray the aphids?

## 7. Keep the nectar flowing

*Design through time* · **When it appears:** Bees visit the garden (flowers and a bird bath); any season except winter.

**The task.** Build a three-season nectar calendar. Match one plant to spring, summer and autumn so food never disappears.

**Solution.** Spring: *Willow catkins* · Summer: *Borage flowers* · Autumn: *Ivy flowers*.

**Why.** Willow catkins feed early pollinators, borage carries them through summer and ivy flowers provide vital late nectar in autumn.

**Ask the group.** What happens to pollinators when everything flowers in the same month?

## 8. Make room for winter

*Fair share for wildlife* · **When it appears:** Every winter.

**The task.** Find the most suitable winter home for each animal. The clues are in how they live and feed.

**Solution.** *Hedgehog → Deep leaf pile* · *Ladybug → Hollow stems* · *Earthworm → Active compost* · *Butterfly chrysalis → Dense woody corner*.

**Why.** Undisturbed leaf piles can shelter hedgehogs, hollow stems protect some overwintering insects, active compost buffers soil organisms and dense woody corners can hold butterfly chrysalises.

**Ask the group.** Which of these winter homes could you leave in a real garden this autumn?

## 9. Complete the connection

*Connect, don't collect* · **When it appears:** The group has found at least two design connections.

**The task.** For each familiar garden element, choose the partner that completes a useful connection you have already discovered.

**Solution.**

For each element, the partner from a connection the group has found (the game asks about up to three of them):

- *Compost → Greenhouse* (Hot-bed idea)
- *Rain harvesting → Herb spiral* (Drip corner)
- *Hügelkultur bed → Growing arch* (Food forest corner)
- *Bug hotel → Flower strip* (Pollinator paradise)
- *Seed bank → Flower strip* (Living seed library)
- *Bench → Garden sign* (Outdoor classroom)
- *Mulch / no-dig → Flower strip* (Nectar and cover)
- *Bird house → Hügelkultur bed* (Bird neighbours)

**Why.** A proposed connection links possible needs and yields — heat, water, shelter, food or learning — but each relationship remains a hypothesis to observe and adjust on the real site. A full guild combines several such roles.

**Ask the group.** What does each element give the other, and what would turn a pair into a fuller guild?

## 10. Choose tomorrow's seeds

*Save what thrives* · **When it appears:** A seed bank is in the garden; autumn.

**The task.** Inspect each simplified seed batch and decide whether to store it, wait for better conditions, or reject it. Real crops may require species-specific guidance.

**Solution.**

- *Dry herb seed heads → Store in seed bank*

- *Green lettuce seed heads → Wait & dry*
- *Pods after morning rain → Wait & dry*
- *Mouldy seed batch → Reject this batch*
- *Clean cabbage pods → Store in seed bank*

**Why.** Save fully dry, mature seed from suitable open-pollinated plants. Hybrid offspring may not resemble the parent, and cross-pollinating crops need enough plants and suitable isolation. Disease risk is crop- and pathogen-specific: visibly mouldy seed should not be stored, while a symptom on the parent does not automatically mean every seed is unsafe.

**Ask the group.** Why is the biggest handful not always the best seed to keep?

## 11. Read the garden

*Observe before acting* · **When it appears:** Any season, when the other challenges have had their turn or none of them fits the garden.

**The task.** Work through three garden situations. Choose the response that solves today's problem without creating tomorrow's.

**Solution.**

Three of these four situations, in any order:

- Three hot, dry days are forecast and the young beds are wilting. → *Water deeply in the morning*
- You want a new bed on lawn without damaging the soil web. → *Layer cardboard, compost & mulch*
- Slugs are nibbling new seedlings after a wet week. → *Protect seedlings & observe at night*
- The garden has more fresh greens than your group can eat today. → *Share fresh & preserve the rest*

**Why.** Permaculture decisions favour observation, soil cover, living relationships, low disturbance and sharing surplus. The best answer usually solves more than one problem.

**Ask the group.** Which answer solved today's problem without creating tomorrow's?

# Session plans and the closing conversation

## Questions for the closing conversation

Ask, wait, and let the group answer before you add anything. Choose three or four.

**Design connections**

- Which two elements in your garden help each other? What does each one give, and what does it need?
- What is the difference between a useful pair and a full plant guild?
- Which connection surprised you, and how did you find it?

**Fair share and the community table**

- What are shares in this game, and what are they not?
- Why does a gift never buy anything back here? Was that fair?
- What did the community table do for your garden, and was it ever promised?
- Where around you do things circulate as gifts rather than purchases?

**Seasons and challenges**

- What changed when the season turned?
- Which challenge made you change your mind, and what was the clue?

**Back to a real place**

- Which relationship from your garden would you try first in a real one, and why?
- What could you do this week: cover one patch of bare soil, watch where one rainfall goes, leave one quiet corner for wild neighbours?

## 45 minutes

| Time | What happens |
|---|---|
| 0–5 | Welcome. Ask: *What does a garden need besides plants?* Collect a few answers. |
| 5–8 | Open the workshop link on the devices. Choose **the third act** as the start point. |
| 8–30 | Groups of two or three play the third, fourth and fifth acts. Walk round with *Workshop*: ask each group its act's question. |
| 30–37 | Everyone turns to the next season and meets a challenge (the sixth act). |
| 37–45 | Closing conversation: one question on connections, one on fair share, one on a real place. Save or print the logs if you want them. |

Starting at the third act leaves soil and water already in place, so a short session reaches wild neighbours and the community table. Name the first two acts in the welcome so the group knows where the garden began.

## 90 minutes

| Time | What happens |
|---|---|
| 0–10 | Welcome and the opening story, shown on one screen for everyone. |
| 10–15 | Open the workshop link. Start point: **the first act** (the story has been seen). |
| 15–40 | The first four acts. After the second act, stop for two minutes: *Where does the rain go now?* |
| 40–55 | The fifth act: the first gift. Talk about shares, the shared fund and why a gift buys nothing back. |
| 55–75 | The sixth act and further seasons. Groups solve challenges and tell each other the clues they found. |
| 75–90 | Closing conversation (four questions). Groups that reached the flourishing ending save or print their certificate. Save or print the logs. |

## 120 minutes

| Time | What happens |
|---|---|
| 0–10 | Welcome. Each group starts with **the opening story** on its own device. |
| 10–40 | The first three acts, at each group's own pace. |
| 40–55 | Break, or a walk outside: find bare soil, a gutter, a place where rain soaks in or runs away. |
| 55–75 | The fourth and fifth acts: wild neighbours, the first gift, the community table. |
| 75–100 | Seasons and challenges. The flourishing ending needs a full year, every living layer at 45% or more, two active connections, two gifts, a harvest and three different challenges. |
| 100–120 | Closing conversation, certificates for the groups that reached the flourishing ending, saved or printed logs. |

## If something goes wrong

- **A group does not know what to do.** The card at the top left (on a tablet or phone, under *Build*) shows the current act and what it asks for. The question for that act in *Workshop* often helps more than an instruction.
- **A challenge feels stuck.** A wrong choice gives a clue; read it together. A challenge can also be left for later and comes back.
- **The Living Lesson does not show an AI answer.** In workshop mode it always answers from the game's reviewed offline lessons. That is intended.
- **The sound is too much.** The speaker button in the header switches it off for that device.
- **The page will not load.** Without a connection the game opens only on a device where it was downloaded beforehand (*Play without a connection*); otherwise reopen the link once the device is online. The workshop garden stays where it was.
- **The next group arrives.** *Workshop → Prepare for the next group*. Anyone's own game on the device stays as it is.